

| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

Until very recently, the CPI(M)'s faith in the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was so implicit that every time a controversial case came up, party leaders led the chorus for a takeover of cases by the bureau. All that has changed now. "The CBI is nothing more than a tool in the hands of the Centre to use against its political opponents," said state Home Minister Koderi Balakrishnan, who had just a month ago demanded that the CBI be asked to investigate the Marad communal carnage of 2003. What prompted the sudden turnaround was the agency's naming of the powerful state party Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan in the charge-sheet in Rs 390-crore Lavalin case. The case related to the awarding of a contract to SNC Lavalin, a Canada-based firm for renovation of three hydro-electric projects in the state in the mid-1990s when Vijayan was state power minister. The developments have exacerbated tensions within the faction-ridden CPI(M) in Kerala where



The Communist MANIFESTATION

The fratricidal war in the state CPI(M) escalates as the CBI charge-sheets Vijayan in the Lavalin case

Vijayan and Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan are at loggerheads.

No sooner had the CBI revealed the charge-sheet against Vijayan that the chief minister took the next flight to Delhi to meet CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat and requested him to immediately drop Vijayan as the state secretary. He warned Karat that a "tainted leader" would be an embarrassment to the party in the coming general elections. Even as early as 2006, Achuthanandan had submitted a

500-page file to the Politburo with details about irregularities in the award of the contract, citing Vijayan's alleged role in the scam. He has reiterated that the CPI(M)'s moral image is at risk as it is the first time a Politburo member has been implicated thus.

The Politburo's immediate reaction, however, has been to rally behind Vijayan and rubbish the CBI's implication as the UPA Government's misuse of the agency to settle political scores. "We will expose this political game in

the people's court. It is a cheap attempt to take political advantage in the run-up to the elections," said a Politburo statement. "The CPI(M) knows what to do with its secretary. We will not yield to pressures from the Congress and the bourgeois media to remove our state secretary," said S. Ramachandran Pillai, a Politburo member. The BJP has also charged other Politburo members of playing a role in the scam and has said that that was the reason they were defending Vijayan.

